

DREAMING AGES HISTORY · EPISODE 14

Was Dracula Real?

Halloween Sleep Story for Adults

A Night in Transylvania

✦ ✦ ✦

A BEDTIME COMPANION

Two maps, a timeline from the Order of the Dragon to the first Dracula on film, the people and places you'll meet in the episode, and a short list of trusted books and museums, for the evenings when you would like to wander a little further.

WATCH ON YOUTUBE

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Garlic on the doors

Let's begin in a village beyond the forest, on St Andrew's Eve.



Places plotted at their real locations on a modern base map (Natural Earth). The episode's village is imagined and is not on the map.

AT A GLANCE

- St Andrew's Eve, 29–30 November
- Garlic was rubbed on doors, windows and chimneys
- The garlic was guarded through the night, against the strigoi

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Places you'll visit in the episode

Nine places from the episode, from Sibiu to Whitby.

Sibiu and Brașov · Hermannstadt and Kronstadt, where Emily Gerard lived from 1883 to 1885.

Sighișoara · By tradition the birthplace of Vlad III.

Bran · The gorge Vlad may have passed through; there is no evidence Stoker knew of the castle.

Snagov · The island monastery near Bucharest where, by tradition, Vlad is buried; no one can be sure.

Kisiljevo · The Serbian village of Petar Blagojević, 1725.

Medveđa · On the West Morava, where Flückinger's commission came in January 1732.

Belgrade · Where the commission set out and the report was signed.

Vienna · Where the reports were printed and Maria Theresa gave her order of 1755.

Whitby · The Yorkshire harbour where Stoker spent the summer of 1890 and found the name, most likely, in the library.

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A timeline of the story

From the Order of the Dragon to the first Dracula on film, one quiet step at a time.

AT A GLANCE

1725 — Vampyri in German

1890 — Stoker in Whitby

1897 — Dracula published

1047	The Old Russian name “Upyr” is written down.
1408	The Order of the Dragon is founded; Vlad II later joins it and is called Dracul.
c. 1428–1431	Vlad III, “son of Dracul”, is born.
1456–1462	Vlad III’s main reign in Wallachia.
1476/77	Vlad III dies.
1718	By the Treaty of Passarowitz the Habsburgs gain northern Serbia.
1725	Frombald reports on Kisiljevo; the word Vampyri appears in German.
1732	Flückinger’s Visum et Repertum on Medveđa; London papers print “Vampyres”.
1746	Dom Augustin Calmet’s dissertation on revenants and vampires.
1755	Maria Theresa orders that superstition be stopped.
1816	A rainy summer at the Villa Diodati.

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A timeline of the story

The story goes on from here, slowly.



1819	Polidori's The Vampyre is published.
1820	William Wilkinson's book on Wallachia, with its footnote on "Dracula".
1871–1872	Le Fanu's Carmilla, set in Styria.
1885	Emily Gerard's "Transylvanian Superstitions".
1890	Stoker's notes begin in March; his Whitby holiday in July and August.
1897	Dracula is published in London on 26 May.
1912	Stoker dies on 20 April.
1924–1931	Hamilton Deane's play, then Bela Lugosi in the Universal film.

Vlad III's birth and death years, birthplace and burial place are uncertain or traditional.

HOW THE VAMPIRE TRAVELLED

From the village to the novel

Now let's follow the vampire from the villages to the novel.



Places in the vampire's journey from village reports to Stoker's novel, on a modern base map (Natural Earth).

People you'll meet

The princes, doctors and writers you'll meet along the way.

Vlad II Dracul · Prince of Wallachia and knight of the Order of the Dragon.

Vlad III · His son, "Drăculea", never a vampire in Romanian tradition.

Petar Blagojević · The villager of Kisiljevo whose case was reported in 1725.

Arnold Paole · The soldier of Medveđa whose story began the 1732 inquiry.

Johann Flückinger · Army surgeon who wrote Visum et Repertum.

Augustin Calmet · Benedictine scholar of Senones who wrote on revenants and vampires.

Maria Theresa · Empress whose doctors called the fear "superstitious credulity".

John Polidori · Byron's doctor, author of The Vampyre.

William Wilkinson · English agent in Bucharest whose 1820 book named Dracula.

Emily Gerard · Scottish writer who lived in Transylvania and described its beliefs.

Bram Stoker · Dublin-born theatre manager and author of Dracula.

Bela Lugosi · Actor born in Lugoj in the Banat, the Count of 1931.

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WHILE YOU LISTEN

Things to spot, legend and history

A few things to listen for, and a note on legend and history.

THINGS TO SPOT IN THE EPISODE

- Garlic guarded through St Andrew's night
- Frombald's report from Kisiljevo in 1725
- The empress's doctors in 1755
- The footnote in Wilkinson's book of 1820
- Stoker's holiday in Whitby in 1890

LEGEND OR HISTORY?

Stoker took the name Dracula from a footnote, not from Vlad III's life: Vlad is not named in Stoker's notes. "Dracula means devil" is Wilkinson's simplification of "son of the Dragon". There is no evidence Stoker knew of Bran Castle, "nosferatu" is not a recognised Romanian word, and the golden cup at Vlad's fountain is a legend. The village, Floarea and Ileana are imagined; the customs, people and documents are real.





Artistic impressions of Whitby and of a Transylvanian Saxon town, made for the episode. They are not historical records.

FOR ANOTHER QUIET EVENING

Books to read

If you'd like to wander a little further, here are some trusted places to start.

Dracula ↗, Bram Stoker, ed. Roger Luckhurst (Oxford World's Classics, 2011).

Bram Stoker's Notes for Dracula ↗, ed. Robert Eighteen-Bisang and Elizabeth Miller (McFarland, 2008).

Dracula: Sense & Nonsense ↗, Elizabeth Miller (Desert Island Books, 2000).

Vampires, Burial, and Death: Folklore and Reality ↗, Paul Barber (Yale University Press, new ed., 2010).

📚 FIND THESE BOOKS — TAP HERE →

Full reading list ↗

FOR ANOTHER QUIET EVENING

Museums, places and one last thought

Museums & places

Whitby Museum, Pannett Park, Whitby.

Whitby Abbey, English Heritage.

The Rosenbach, Philadelphia: home of Stoker's working notes for Dracula.

A BEDTIME QUESTION

If you kept watch tonight, would you guard the garlic, or listen for the cock to crow?

"The garlic is guarded, the cock has crowed, and the long night beyond the forest is over."

LISTEN TO THE FULL EPISODE ON YOUTUBE OR YOUTUBE MUSIC

Watch the episode: youtube.com/watch?v=zF9tFYISrtE

Dreaming Ages History · Narration is AI-generated text-to-speech; illustrations are AI-generated artistic impressions. Facts follow the episode script and its sources. Maps drawn from real coordinates: Natural Earth; historical borders simplified from the open historical-basemaps dataset (A. Ourednik). Free for personal use. Sleep well. 🌙